As for someone who didn't play for Pakistan but would be great to have on one's side, Brian Lara is enviable. His talent, attitude, openness and friendliness are very inspiring. We have hung out a couple of times; he lives life to the fullest. His fame, his style and his personality, his left-handed elegance: he would have been a great teammate. But, no offence to Lara, I'd never be a left-hander. If I were to start again, I'd always be a right-hander – although I wouldn't mind having Lara's natural flair. Compared to his graceful strokeplay, my shot selection looks clumsy. He is a maestro to my butcher.

Speaking of grace, now that we are on the topic of my favourites, here's my list for what would be my all-time best Pakistan XI, World XI and yes, even a Pakistan–India Joint XI. (Disclaimer: This is a strictly professional opinion. No politics were conducted or grudges held during the formation of these rosters.)

So, without further ado, my all-time best Pakistan XI:

1. Saeed Anwar: Pakistan never saw an opener like him, and probably never will. The strongest opener we've ever had. Aggressive in battle, a Karachiite in mental toughness.
2. Aamer Sohail: A brave player. Classy. You need to be brave to open.
3. Inzamam-ul-Haq: Backbone. The top of any middle order.
4. Mohammad Yousuf: Top class. Great technique. You need his orthodoxy on the field.
5. Javed Miandad: Wily. Situation-savvy. Makes the middle order tick in any condition or situation.
6. Imran Khan: Best skipper and all-rounder we've had. Period.
7. Shahid Afridi: Pathan. Game changer.
8. Rashid Latif: The toughest wicketkeeper ever born between Dhaka and Peshawar.
9. Wasim Akram: The king of the new ball, the commander of the old ball. The sultan of swing.
10. Waqar Younis: The bullet which comes in from the other end if Wasim is on from one end. You can't not have the two Ws together.
11. Shoaib Akhtar: Ferocious. Furious. Complex on and off the field, but makes batsmen think of their mothers at least twice in an over.

Without a doubt, Imran Khan would be skipper of this side.

Now, for my all-time best World XI:

1. Saeed Anwar: As explained earlier.
2. Sachin Tendulkar: World class. Legend. I'd have him open. Always.
3. Virat Kohli: This was a tough one. He's the top No. 3 guy. There are other great No. 3 guys, like Ponting, but for me, it's Kohli. You want to see him bat and bat and bat. But I'm almost tempted to repeat what a fan infamously said to him at the Champions Trophy final in 2017 in London when India lost to Pakistan: 'Kohli, *nahin hota tujhse* chase!'
4. AB de Villiers: Top-class skills. Very diverse in all formats. My kind of guy.
5. Inzamam-ul-Haq: As explained earlier.